

Conflict Guide

The four horsemen and their antidotes, the flowchart, "I" statements, timeouts, repair, agreement and gratitude · Module 6, Training 2

The science (Gottman Institute research)

Happy couples fight; what predicts trouble is *how*. Four behaviours predicted separation: **criticism, contempt, defensiveness, stonewalling**. Above about **100 beats per minute** a person is flooded and cannot listen; couples who took a **20-minute break and returned** did far better than those who pushed on. Thriving couples showed about **five positive interactions for every negative one** during conflict. Raising issues gently within a day or two beat storing them up; partners who **accepted influence** ("that's fair, let's do it your way") had more stable relationships.

HORSEMAN	SOUNDS LIKE	ANTIDOTE
Criticism (attacking character)	"You're so lazy about this"	Gentle start-up: "I feel... when... I'd like..."
Contempt (mockery, eye-rolling)	"Oh, <i>now</i> you care"	Culture of appreciation: the nightly gratitude share (Module 4)
Defensiveness (counter-complaint)	"Well, you never..."	Take responsibility for a part: "You're right that I didn't ask"
Stonewalling (shutting down)	silence, leaving the room	Structured timeout with a return time

The health-habit fights on this journey

Pace ("easing in" reads as "not trying") · Policing (comments on the plate) · Money (organic, filters, supplements) · Coping (talk it out vs. go for a run) · and underneath: "You don't want this as much as I do."

The flowchart

1. **Soft start-up** within a day or two, calm, not at 11 p.m.
2. **"I" statement** — "I feel ____ when ____, because ____, and I'd like ____."
3. **Listen** with the loop (Training 1): reflect, check, one open question.

4. **Flooded?** (racing heart, raised voice, urge to leave) → say the agreed word: "pause" → **20 minutes apart** doing something calming (breathing from Module 4, not rehearsing your point) → **return at the agreed time** (non-negotiable).
5. **Repair** — "Can we start over?" · "That came out harsh, I'm sorry." · "I'm on your side here." · a hand on the arm. Offer them; accept them.
6. **Agreement** — one small specific thing each of you will do.
7. **Gratitude** — one thanks each for something the other did in the conversation.

"I" statement builder

I FEEL...	WHEN... (SPECIFIC BEHAVIOUR, NOT CHARACTER)	BECAUSE... (WHAT IT MEANS TO ME)	AND I'D LIKE... (A REQUEST)
scared	the sweets come back into the house	I'm working so hard on my cravings	us to keep them where I don't see them

Our timeout agreement

Our word: _____ Minimum break: 20 min Return time is set before we separate: ☐ agreed What each of us does during the break (not rehearsing): _____ / _____

Resolve one issue (50 XP)

The issue (small and early, not the biggest one): _____

My "I" statement: _____

What I heard when I listened (their words): _____

Repair offered / accepted: ☐ / ☐

Our agreement (one small specific thing each): _____ / _____

Gratitude (one each): _____ / _____

Journal the outcome (30 XP)

How the conversation went, honestly, and what I'd do differently:

Which horseman showed up, and which antidote helped:

Share anonymously (20 XP)

Post the outcome, not the details: what worked, what didn't.

When to get help

If the same fight repeats without resolution, if contempt has become the norm, or if either of you feels unsafe, a couples counsellor is the next step, and many fertility clinics can refer you. It is a sign of two people taking the relationship seriously.

Educational content only, not medical advice. Always consult your doctor or a qualified health professional before changing supplements, diet, exercise or detox practices, especially while trying to conceive.